relations. On the latter, neither American allies nor Congress wanted to do much in terms of economic assistance, so Brzezinski suggested focusing on political relationships with "emerging, more influential developing countries." This meant more high-level visits and exchanges, consultative groups, and greater security cooperation (including arms sales and intelligence sharing). For him, in this regard, India was the country that stood out.[109] And it was clear from Desai's warm responses to Carter that Delhi was open to a reset.[110]

A series of steps followed that reflected and facilitated an improvement in US-India ties. In June, Carter decided against the sale of A-7 military aircraft to Pakistan. And the administration got a long-held-up nuclear fuel shipment for India's Tarapur reactor approved.[111] Then in July Christopher visited Delhi, where he acknowledged India as "the leader of South Asia."[112]

Carter also approved a series of recommendations for improving relations with India, Indonesia, and Nigeria. The administration decided to invite Desai for a visit (there had not been a leader-level meeting since 1971); plan a presidential or vice presidential trip; increase academic exchanges; propose confidential consultations on India's development needs; offer satellite technology; keep Delhi informed of US policy toward the Soviet Union, China, and South Asia; and consult regularly on Africa.[113] There would also be trips by the US chief of naval operations in September and Secretary of State Vance in December, and an invitation for the Indian chief of army staff to visit as well. The administration also decided to reconsider arms sales policy, since India was seeking to reduce its dependence on Moscow.[114]

The Desai government was indeed looking for balance in foreign policy but understood the importance of the Soviet relationship for India. Moreover, it had to protect itself domestically against allegations that the government would swing too far toward the West and become its "satellite."[115] Finally, preserving the Soviet relationship would create space for moving forward with the US and others. Thus, soon after the government took office, Vajpayee had met with the Soviet ambassador and extended an invitation to Foreign Minister Andrei Gromyko. The Soviet defense minister had also visited India. And the Soviet deputy foreign minister had met with Indian officials in June to encourage them to do more